

NIRODH

Sexy Shades

Red isn't any longer the only colour of passion. It's black, pink, green, violet, orange and, if you've been looking closely at recent advertisements, "sub-zero blue". In fact, the sex life of adult Indians now seems definitely beyond the pale—ever since the advent of multicoloured luxury condoms. But the hues and ahs that accompanied the first flush of libidos are now punctuated with a few cries as well. As competition in the upmarket business of colour condoms gets keener, the Government has leapt into the fray to look for the pot of gold at the end of the rainbow. A Madras-based company, London Rubber Company (India) of the TT Krishnamachari and Sons Group—TTK for short—in a joint venture with the British London Rubber Company, was the first to hit the market in 1979 with the Kohinoor pink condom. This proved to be such a success that the company's joint managing director T.T. Vasu likens its arrival "to the coming of the pink panther". It was followed in November last with Fiesta—the brand name for all-colour condoms. An aggressive sales campaign (the miracle of the sheath according to the blurb in the ad made the young girl's "cold hauteur" melt in seconds) was followed by a massive expansion programme: with the start last February of their 150-million-pieces-a-year plant in Aurangabad, Maharashtra, the company was adding substantially to its existing 225 million pieces a year in Pallavaram on the outskirts of Madras, 25 per cent of which are in colour.

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SHIELD FACTOR:
Final condom checking at a factory in Kerala



SHANKAR

private manufacturers was barely one million and at 25 paise, the price was almost the same as in the US markets. In effect, they were available only to a few rich while population growth rate was highest among the lower income groups. To tackle this, the IIM team suggested that the government import condoms and sell them at a price accessible to the average Indian. The price recommended by them—5 paise per condom—was one-fifth the prevailing price and about 0.5 per cent of the national per capita income. The next major issue was that of marketing for which the government roped in five corporate majors. Top agencies worked on the ad campaign. In 1968, the first shipment of 400 million condoms (one per capita of population) was imported from the US, Japan and Korea. All had identical packaging, each box containing three condoms and all branded Nirodh.

A three-pronged distribution system was worked out which involved free supply to health centres, social marketing which took up 75 per cent of the supply and commercial marketing. In the first few years, three-fourth of the stocks remained idle with distributors. But gradually things began to change. In 1969, Hindustan Latex Ltd (HLL) set up the first condom factory in Thiruvananthapuram with an annual production of 144 million pieces. The production doubled in seven years which competed with population growth to touch 800 million by 1985 with another manufacturing unit in Belgaum, Karnataka. Now HLL produces the world's largest variety of condoms. Though the Indian population has more than doubled in the last three decades and is predicted to be the world's largest by 2050, the growth rate has fallen from 2.4 per cent in 1964 to 1.8 per cent in 2005. And much of the credit goes to the humble Nirodh. ■